Case Study

Building GenAI Accountability Blueprint for the Washington State Office of Equity

Client Background

The Washington State Office of Equity was established to embed equity across all functions of state government. Tasked with reducing disparities and ensuring fair outcomes for all Washingtonians, the Office leads efforts to reform how government systems serve historically marginalized communities. In January 2024, the Governor issued Executive Order 24-01, requiring the Office to spearhead the development of a framework that would guide the fair, ethical, and equitable use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GenAI) across state agencies.

Challenges

The Office faced several intersecting challenges:

- There was no existing accountability model for the equitable use of GenAI.
- Government agencies operated in silos, with inconsistent AI adoption practices and no coordinated monitoring structure.
- Communities expressed distrust toward AI tools, particularly in their application by government and law enforcement.
- The Office needed to deliver actionable guidance by September 2024, per the executive mandate.
- The blueprint needed to balance technical detail with community input, ensuring accessibility and clarity.

Approach

To address these challenges, the Office of Equity brought in Taliferro Tech as the primary Subject Matter Expert (SME) to shape technical guidance, ethical risk management, and community-responsive recommendations. Taliferro introduced a series of proprietary AI methodologies to the blueprint's architecture:

- **Adaptive Learning Pathways (ALP)**: Used to create training guidance for state systems that evolve based on usage scenarios.
- **Bias Correction Mechanism (BCM)** and **Bias Drift Detection**: Ensured agencies could detect and respond to bias in real-time and across time.
- **Consistent Output Protocol (COP)**: Reinforced Taliferro’s standard for factual, repeatable GenAI outputs.
- **Contextual Insight Mapping (CIM)** and **Contextual Data Amplification (CDA)**: Helped translate raw government data into actionable, context-aware insights.
- **Fairness Module** and **Bias Indicator**: Designed to monitor and alert users of bias during GenAI inferences.
- **External Bias API**: Allowed integration of community feedback directly into model refinement cycles.

Taliferro Tech also drafted Appendix D: "Checklist of Considerations," now published in the GenAI Accountability Blueprint, which provided operational questions and safeguards for agencies deploying GenAI.

Partnerships or Collaborations

The project required a multi-stakeholder approach. Taliferro worked alongside:

- The Office of Equity's Innovation and Performance team
- Washington Technology Solutions (WaTech)
- Office of Financial Management (OFM)
- Department of Enterprise Services (DES)
- The Community Advisory Board (CAB)

These partners contributed lived experience, technical policy expertise, and real-world context for how government technologies affect different communities.

Results and Impact

- The GenAI Accountability Blueprint was published in September 2024.
- Taliferro's checklist (Appendix D) is being considered for a separate website for guidance.
- Agencies gained foundational guidance to inform their AI governance models.
- The CAB's qualitative insights were incorporated directly into the framework, reflecting public perception and concern.
- The state now has a baseline for ethical GenAI use, with plans to evolve into a full Accountability Framework.

Procurement & Legal Safeguards

The GenAI Accountability Blueprint also serves a protective function for state departments and agencies. By aligning procurement decisions with the framework, agencies can:

- Establish due diligence: Agencies that adopt the Blueprint's checklist (Appendix D) and bias mitigation guidelines can demonstrate a thorough review process when evaluating GenAI vendors, reducing liability if system failures or bias-related issues arise.
- Standardize vendor requirements: The framework helps procurement teams define clear requirements for GenAI tools, including bias detection, explainability, and equity impact, which can be embedded into RFPs and contracts.
- Justify rejections: If a GenAI product lacks transparency, equity safeguards, or real-time monitoring, the framework gives agencies a reasoned, policy-backed rationale for rejecting the solution.
- Support compliance documentation: The Blueprint creates a consistent reference point for audits, public records requests, or legal challenges, showing that the agency followed an enterprise-wide standard for responsible AI.

Taliferro Tech's contributions, especially tools like the Bias Indicator, Fairness Module, and Consistent Output Protocol (COP), reinforce these protections by offering agencies tangible ways to implement and prove adherence to the Blueprint.

Quantitative and Qualitative Data

- Over 80% of CAB survey respondents found GenAI potentially enabling but raised trust and transparency concerns.
- Appendix D is being considered as foundational in their internal AI guidelines.
- CAB members highlighted Taliferro's tools as vital for real-time bias response, citing tools like the Bias Indicator and BCM.

Insights on Best Practices

- Combine technical AI tools with plain-language governance strategies.

- Engage communities not just during outreach, but throughout the technical development.
- Implement real-time feedback loops such as the External Bias API to ensure systems evolve with user experiences.
- Prioritize tools like the Fairness Module and COP to build AI systems that are explainable, repeatable, and trusted.

Key Points Summarized

- **Client**: Washington State Office of Equity
- **Mandate**: Develop an equity-first accountability structure for Generative AI
- **Challenge**: Build technical policy that aligns with public trust and real-time risk management
- **Solution**: Taliferro's AI methodologies integrated into a public governance document
- **Impact**: A replicable blueprint now used by multiple state agencies

Conclusion

The Washington State Office of Equity's GenAI Accountability Blueprint is a bold step toward responsible, community-centered technology governance. With Taliferro Tech's real-time tools and equity-focused AI methods, the state now has a replicable model for fair AI usage. Taliferro's approach didn't just meet the moment—it created a foundation that ensures accountability is measurable, transparent, and inclusive of all Washingtonians.